again, there were two rooms, one with three windows, and above that there were the two attic rooms in which the children lived.' Throughout his life, in interviews and profiles, he spoke of his father with intense pride. A short man, standing at 5ft 9in tall, Wilhelm had piercing brown eyes and wiry tan hair which turned greyish in his late twenties. He must have had a strong character, both physically and mentally, to cope with a life spent in the mines as works' steward and safety officer, which, as Erich recalled, 'meant he must go in and decide whether there was clean air below. He had to conduct the wages struggle. He was a member of the miners' union – he had the trust of the workforce.' Given the high levels of sickness, Wilhelm developed his own reputation and was permanently in conflict with the pit's management. 'I honoured my father before everything because he was a straightforward person, an honest man. I honour his stand for the miners at his pit. I can say that my father was always the role model for my entire life'. Outside work, Wilhelm also attained, and then held for more than ten years, a seat on the local council.

Two years after Erich's birth, when war broke out in 1914, his father was mobilised into the German Navy. Like everyone else, he could have hardly imagined the conflict would spiral far beyond Europe and introduce the world to the horrors of chemical weapons and air-raids – as well as the toppling of a Tsar, a Kaiser and an Emperor. Never would so many men take up arms in a conflict that would leave nine million dead.

All this weighed heavily on the family, given Wilhelm's low military salary squeezed their daily lives. 'My mother,' Honecker confided, 'had to care for the five urchins herself, including clothing. It is well known that during the First World War there was hunger at home everywhere, not only in our family.' Rationing allowed eight grams of butter and two loaves of bread per fortnight, one egg and a half-pound of meat per week. When times got tough, the family was thankful for their skinny-ribbed cow, rabbits, vegetable patch and fruit trees. The bread was often indigestible; and potatoes, milk and lard were scarce. Despite this, Karoline kept the children clothed with home-tailored coats, shirts and undergarments. 'I cannot remember that anyone, other than my mother, made our clothes. She also had to earn money for the family by wafting from house to house delivering newspapers.'1 The war, it seems, left its most powerful mark on Honecker's